

THE BOG OF
THE SEVENTH HEART
BOOK EIGHT

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The Bog of the Seven Hearts

Book Eight of
The Seven Bogs of Mars

by

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Dedication

For those who walked the path
without knowing where it would lead,

and still continued.

For the quiet ones,
who listened long enough
to remember.

Epigraph

It was not separate.

It was never separate.

What lived in one
lived in all.

And when the seven awakened,
they did not stand apart—
they remembered
they were one.

The Seven Bogs of Mars

Book One — The Seven Bogs of Mars

Book Two — The Bog of Patience

Book Three — The Bog of Silence

Book Four — The Bog of Movement

Book Five — The Bog of Restraint

Book Six — The Bog of Passage

Book Seven — The Bog of
Interconnection

Book Eight — The Bog of the Seven
Hearts

Chapter One— The Seventh

They had awakened the six.

But the seventh had never been waiting.

It had always been there.

It did not stir as the others had.

There was no shift in the ground,
no tremor beneath the roots,
no rising of forgotten breath.

The bog lay as it had always lain—
quiet,
unchanged,
whole.

Asa stood at its edge and did not step forward.

He had learned that much.

The first had taught him patience.

The second had taught him to listen.

The third had shown him movement.

The fourth had shown him restraint.

The fifth had opened passage.

The sixth had woven what had been separate.

Each had called him in its own way.

This one did not.

The stillness before him was not empty.

It was complete.

Saxifraga came to stand beside him,
though he had not heard her approach. He
did not turn. He did not need to.

“You feel it,” she said.

It was not a question.

“Yes,” Asa answered.

He searched for the right word and found
none that fit.

“It isn’t like the others.”

“No,” she said quietly. “It is not.”

The surface of the bog reflected no sky.

There was no ripple, no disturbance, no trace of the wind that moved across the plains behind them. Even the light seemed to rest differently here—settling, rather than passing.

Asa took a slow breath.

The bees had come with him.

He had not called them.

They had followed, as they always did now, moving in a loose, living current around him. But here—at the edge of this place—they did not enter.

They hovered.

Not in hesitation.

In recognition.

He watched them for a long moment.

Usually they spread outward, searching,
carrying, mapping the unseen.

Here, they gathered.

Not as many.

Not as one.

But as something that no longer needed to
choose between the two.

Saxifraga's gaze followed his.

“They know,” she said.

“What do they know?” Asa asked.

“That this one does not need to be awakened.”

He frowned slightly, not in disagreement, but in the effort to understand what was already beginning to settle into him.

“All the others needed something,” he said. “Patience. Silence. Movement... even restraint.”

“And this one?” she asked.

Asa looked out across the still surface again.

For a long time, he did not answer.

When he did, his voice was quieter.

“This one doesn’t need anything.”

The words did not feel like a conclusion.

They felt like something remembered.

A wind moved behind them, bending the distant growth in a slow, sweeping motion. It did not reach the bog.

Nothing disturbed its surface.

Asa took a step forward.

Not into it.

Closer.

Close enough that he could see beneath the surface—not depth, not reflection, but something else. Not layers. Not distance.

Presence.

It did not look back at him.

It did not reach.

It did not change.

And yet, standing there, he felt something he had not felt in any of the other bogs.

Not resistance.

Not invitation.

Not even recognition.

Belonging.

It was not something given.

It was not something earned.

It simply was.

He exhaled slowly.

“I don’t know what to do,” he said.

Saxifraga did not answer at once.

When she did, her voice carried no instruction.

“You are not meant to do anything here.”

Asa let that settle.

Every place before this had asked something of him.

Even when he had not understood it, there had been movement, choice, effort.

Here, there was none.

The bees shifted slightly behind him, their soft hum rising—not louder, but fuller, as if it had found a place to rest within itself.

He closed his eyes for a moment.

Not to search.

Not to listen.

Just to be still.

And in that stillness, something became clear.

Not a thought.

Not a realization.

Something simpler.

He had never been separate from it.

His eyes opened again.

The bog remained unchanged.

But he was not standing apart from it anymore.

Saxifraga watched him, and in her gaze there was something like recognition—not of him, but of what he had come to understand.

“The others,” Asa said slowly, “they brought things back together.”

“Yes,” she said.

“This one...” He paused, then let the words come as they would. “This one was never apart.”

Saxifraga inclined her head slightly.

“The Seventh,” she said, “is not the last.”

Asa looked at her then.

“It is the whole.”

The bees moved then—not outward, not searching—but settling into a quiet, steady hum that seemed to exist both around him and within him.

Asa took one more step forward.

This time, he did not stop at the edge.

And the bog did not change.

But everything that had once felt
separate... did.

“Thank you for reading my sample”